

Guarding the Gatekeepers:

Digital Discovery Summary of C-Suite Resource Misuse

Crystal Brock

Global Campus, Southern New Hampshire University

CYB-320: Incident Response and Investigation

Professor Bill Spettmann

April 17, 2026

Guarding the Gatekeepers: A Digital Discovery Summary of C-Suite Resource Misuse

Policy Breach Evaluation

The current situation involving a high-level executive is a textbook example of executive exceptionalism clashing with established security infrastructure. Based on the initial notice to HR and our preliminary review of the Acceptable Use Policy (AUP), the executive's alleged conduct is in direct violation of Ocwen's standards in several key areas.

First, the AUP clearly states that all computing equipment and network accounts are the sole property of Ocwen and are to be used strictly for business purposes. Conducting side business operations is an explicit breach of Section 4.3.1, which prohibits accessing data or servers for any purpose other than Ocwen business.

Furthermore, while the policy allows for reasonable personal use, running dating ads on company assets, especially when those activities correlate with anomalous network activity, is a failure of the required good judgment mandate. The correlation between the executive's browsing and the recent cybersecurity incident suggests a violation of Section 4.2.5, which requires extreme caution with attachments and unknown senders to prevent malware attacks like the recent one that eventually forced us to restore our systems from backup. Whether this was intentional or just remarkably negligent, the liability created for Ocwen is substantial.

Evidence Locations

To provide HR with a defensible case, given the anomalous activity detected three months ago, we are prioritizing three high-yield evidence locations. Following the framework provided by NIST 800-86, we will prioritize the following (NIST, 2006):

1. Firewall and Proxy Logs (Network-Level):
 - a. This is where we confirm the digital paper trail. These logs will provide a chronological record of the executive's external connections. We aren't just looking for dating site URLs; we are looking for the IP addresses associated with his side business's backend. This establishes a pattern of unauthorized resource consumption during business hours.
2. Host-Based Forensic Artifacts (Workstation Disk Image):
 - a. Since enterprise systems rarely behave exactly as the diagrams suggest, we need the exact imprint of the executive's local disk. We will target browser history, cached profiles from dating sites, and, most importantly, the metadata of any documents related to the side business. This will allow us to map a timeline that likely overlaps with the malware entry point.
3. Physical and Tangible Evidence (Office Search):
 - a. Since digital forensics does not live purely in the virtual realm, we must account for physical artifacts. Per NIJ guidelines, we will search the executive's physical workspace for unauthorized storage media that may contain side-business records hidden from network monitoring (NIJ, 2008). We will also look for other tangible evidence that the executive failed to secure access, directly violating Section 4.2.2.

Procedures for Maintaining Chain of Custody

Given the executive's rank, we anticipate significant pushback. Any gap in the chain of custody will be exploited by legal counsel. Following ISO/IEC 27037 standards, we will treat every artifact as potential courtroom evidence (ISO/IEC, 2012).

The process begins with immediate cryptographic hashing (SHA-256). Every network log exported and every bit-for-bit image taken will be hashed at the moment of acquisition. If a single bit of that evidence is changed during analysis, the hashes won't match, and our report is worthless. For physical items like USBs or external drives, we will use individual evidence bags and tamper-evident tape, documenting the exact date, time, and location of the seizure (NIJ, 2008). Every individual who handles the evidence, from the Digital Evidence Specialist to the IT Manager, must sign a permanent log. This unbroken custodian trail ensures the integrity of the investigation against claims of tampering.

Forensic Tool Requirements

To complete this investigation with the necessary rigor, I require the following resource allocations:

- Software: Magnet AXIOM: This is our primary analysis engine. AXIOM excels at reconstructing a user's digital life by parsing fragments from browser history, social media, and cloud accounts. It is uniquely suited to linking the anomalous network activity to specific file creations on the workstation, providing the smoking gun needed to prove the malware incident was directly related to the executive's unauthorized side-business activity.
- Hardware: Tableau Forensic Bridge (Hardware Write-Blocker): This is our non-negotiable insurance policy. When we image the executive's workstation, we cannot risk his operating system changing file attributes or metadata during the process. The Tableau Bridge physically prevents the workstation from writing to the original evidence drive. This is the only industry-standard way to prove to HR and legal that our forensic images are perfect, untampered duplicates of the executive's actual data (ISO/IEC, 2012).

References

- International Organization for Standardization. (2012) [ISO/IEC, 2012]. Information technology — *Security techniques — Guidelines for identification, collection, acquisition and preservation of digital evidence* (ISO/IEC Standard No. 27037).
<https://www.iso.org/standard/44381.html>
- Kent, K., Chevalier, S., Grance, T., & Dang, H. (2006)[NIST, 2006]. *Guide to Integrating Forensic Techniques into Incident Response* (NIST Special Publication 800-86). National Institute of Standards and Technology.
<https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/Legacy/SP/nistspecialpublication800-86.pdf>
- National Institute of Justice. (2008) [NIJ, 2008]. *Electronic Crime Scene Investigation: A Guide for First Responders* (2nd ed.). U.S. Department of Justice.
<https://www.ojp.gov/pdffiles1/nij/219941.pdf>